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Training and development challenges experienced by employees and managers

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Abstract

Due to rapid increase in technological advancement, dynamic labour markets, performance-oriented forms of work and globalisation, training and development have experienced substantial and far-reaching changes. This has led renewed challenges in the provision of training and development. Although extant research has linked training and development to various organisational outcomes, challenges associated with its execution have not been adequately investigated. Therefore, guided by Human Capital Theory and Social Learning Theory, the current study to explore the training and development complexities at the workplace. The current study used a qualitative approach, grounded in an inductive approach and guided by thematic analysis, to explore participants' personal meanings as shaped by their lived experiences. The study utilised purposive and snowball sampling techniques to select participants who met the researchers' predefined criteria and aligned with the study's objectives. Data were collected through semi-structured interviews conducted with 22 participants, comprising a mix of human resource personnel as well as both new and existing employees drawn from various sectors. This study engaged in thematic analysis with differentiated analysis across participant groups to explore the contextual dynamics shaping the training and development challenges of corporates in South Africa. The findings of this study indicated that the training and development faced by HR personnel include identification of training needs obstacles, unwillingness of employee to participate in training, limited time allocation for training, incompetence of the trainer, difficulties in keeping abreast with accelerating technology, and poor financial and resource support. While veteran employees encounter training and development challenges such as poor execution of the training, poor alignment between training programmes and employees' personal goals, and poor management communication channels, new employees indicated that poor structure and ineffectiveness of induction training. Thus, the study makes a theoretical contribution by showing that employee constraints and management hindrances are not independent phenomena, but deeply intertwined mechanisms shaping training and development. In addition, the study extends Human Capital Theory and Social Learning Theory by demonstrating that workplace training and development challenges are shaped by the interaction between organisational investment in employee capabilities and the social and managerial environments in which learning occurs.

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Keywords Training, Development, Skills development, Human capital theory, Human capital development

1 Introduction

While scholars have extensively researched the linkage of training and development to various organisational outcomes [1, 2 ,3], there has been limited focus on the complexities associated with it. In the context of an increasingly complex economic environment, training and development (T&D) has become a critical contributor to organisational success. Existing studies indicate that the demand for T&D has intensified due to the ongoing need to upskill and reskill employees in response to rapid technological advancements, evolving socio-economic conditions, and continuous industry transformation [4, 5, 6]. These developments have heightened the demand for a more highly skilled workforce. Training and development initiatives are therefore essential in enabling employees to competently respond to both present and emerging workplace challenges [7]. World Economic Forum [8] estimated that by 2025, approximately 50% of employees would require upskilling as a result of skills disruption affecting 40% of existing roles. Furthermore, South Africa is projected to experience skills disruption affecting 36% of jobs by 2030, positioning upskilling and reskilling as central workforce strategies for the coming decade [6].

Extant literature acknowledged the importance role of training and development [9, 10, 11], however the constraints linked to it have not yet been adequately addressed. Training and development increasingly represent a collaborative endeavour between employees and their organisations, wherein both parties jointly develop strategies to promote continuous learning by cultivating supportive learning environments [12, 13]. However, organisations encounter several challenges in implementing continuous learning initiatives. These challenges include identifying the skills most critical for future workforce requirements, ensuring that appropriate training is delivered to the relevant departments or employee groups, providing training that aligns with current labour market demands, and designing training programmes that are inclusive and diverse, often a time-intensive process [14, 15, 16]. Moreover, organisations encounter challenges in formulating effective training strategies across diverse employee levels, addressing resistance from existing staff, and providing adequate support to new employees as they adjust to training requirements, increased job responsibilities, and the organisation's culture and work environment [18, 19, 20].

Skills mismatches and poorly aligned training content have increasingly emerged as persistent challenges within the field of human resource management [21, 22]. In South Africa, unskilled workers accounted for 17.17% of the workforce in 2023 [23, 24], underscoring the urgency of effective training interventions. Consequently, training and development practitioners are required to design relevant, accurate, and up-to-date training materials, supported by appropriate technological enhancements, for both new and existing employees. In addition, they must identify suitable training methods that deliver optimal outcomes while remaining cost-effective [25, 26, 27]. As a result, training and development has become a critical mechanism for ensuring that organisations maintain a competent workforce capable of meeting operational demands. Despite existing literature providing the criticality of training and development, there is a dearth of research

exploring the key challenges related to it. Therefore, the current study sought to accomplish the following research objectives:

- To explore the constraints faced by management in the provision of training and development to employees at the workplace.
- To examine the complexities experienced by both existing and new employees when participating in training and development initiatives at the workplace.
- To investigate the environmental factors that hinder the effectiveness of training and development at the workplace.

2 Literature review

Training and development (T&D) constitute critical drivers of organisational growth [28]. Despite their importance, numerous challenges continue to impede the efficiency and effectiveness of T&D initiatives within the workplace. This section has examined challenges associated with both managerial practices and employee participation. The significance of T&D is closely aligned with organisational objectives and a sustained obligation to constant learning. As reskilling and upskilling are anticipated to become increasingly vital for organisations by 2030, the demand for effective T&D initiatives is expected to intensify further [21, 6]. Despite the unprecedented, technological advancement, dynamic labour markets, performance-oriented forms of work and globalisation, the training and development challenges arise from the changes remain unknown.

The COVID-19 pandemic substantially transformed organisational approaches to work. What initially emerged as a temporary response, remote working, has since evolved into a permanent feature of many organisations' operating models [29]. The effectiveness of remote work arrangements depended largely on organisations' capacity to provide adequate technological tools to sustain connectivity between employees and employers [30]. At the same time, the emergence of the Fourth Industrial Revolution (4IR) has accelerated the integration of human and machine capabilities through sophisticated digital technologies. Nevertheless, in the South African context, the acceptance of 4IR has been constrained by challenges related to government implementation and regulatory frameworks [29]. The rise of hybrid work models has further reshaped how organisations facilitate employee learning and development, whether delivered digitally or through face-to-face modalities. As many training and development programmes were not originally designed to accommodate hybrid work arrangements, organisations have been compelled to redesign and adapt these initiatives. This shift has necessitated innovative approaches to training and development, often resulting in increased organisational costs [31]. Despite these significant changes, challenges related to training remain underexplored, especially in the post-crisis context where many sectors have experienced lasting transformations in their modes of operation.

2.1 The concept of training

Training is defined as a structured and systematic process through which individuals acquire the competencies, knowledge and skills necessary to improve their efficiency and effectiveness in their existing job roles [11]. It encompasses organised learning activities and experiences designed to enhance job-related performance and capabilities. Training may encompass routine job tasks and foundational knowledge or skills and can be delivered through various modalities, including online platforms. Online training has

emerged as a practical and efficient alternative, particularly when face-to-face training is impractical or infeasible [31]. Training is commonly categorised into two primary types, namely off-the-job and on-the-job training. On-the-job training enables staff to develop their knowledge, skills, and abilities through direct engagement with their everyday work activities [14]. This form of training exposes employees to real workplace situations and typically includes methods such as apprenticeship, coaching, job rotation and job instruction [32].

In contrast, off-the-job training takes place outside the immediate work environment and develop skills in external or simulated environment. It may be delivered through in-house programmes at organisational facilities or through off-site training offered by external providers, utilising approaches such as self-directed learning, laboratory-based training, simulations, case studies, and lectures [10]. By emphasising measurable outcomes, training contributes to skill enhancement, the refinement of social behaviours, and overall workforce effectiveness. Effective training management is therefore essential to ensure that training initiatives are appropriately targeted, delivered in suitable formats, and implemented within budgetary constraints [5].

2.2 The Concept of development

Development is conceptualised as a long-term and strategic process focused on preparing individuals with the skills and knowledge necessary to undertake future roles within an organisation [7]. In contrast to training, development adopts a more expansive orientation, prioritising employees' professional growth by enhancing their capabilities beyond the immediate demands of their current roles. Supporting the internal employee development is therefore essential for enhancing career progression opportunities and fostering greater organisational commitment, loyalty, and engagement [29]. Development emphasises understanding organisational processes, tackling anticipated future complexities, and preparing for evolving needs. Within this context, Human Resource Development (HRD) seeks to enhance both employee capabilities and organisational effectiveness in pursuit of long-term growth and strategic objectives. HRD addresses existing challenges, resolves performance gaps, improves operational effectiveness, and continuously updates practices to ensure organisational relevance and sustainability [33].

2.3 Challenges related to training and development

2.3.1 Employee constraints related to training and development

Employee-related challenges in training and development encompass conditions that obstruct the effective planning, delivery, and impact of training and development initiatives in the workplace. In the absence of sufficient training and development opportunities, employees may struggle to fully develop and apply their capabilities in the performance of job-related tasks [4]. These challenges include poorly defined training objectives, which can diminish employees' clarity regarding the purpose and significance of training and development programmes at the workplace. Organisations may also experience difficulties in managing competing demands, as balancing routine work responsibilities alongside training requirements can be overwhelming. In addition, insufficient employee commitment may contribute to the failure of training and development initiatives. When organisations do not provide clear career progression or

growth opportunities, employees may perceive limited value in participating in training and development activities, resulting in reduced engagement [34]. Furthermore, inadequate consideration of employee diversity, including generational differences, cultural backgrounds, expectations, and varied learning preferences, can further undermine the effectiveness of training programmes [18].

2.3.2 Organisational complexities linked to training and development

Organisational-level training and development challenges refer to the constraints and difficulties organisations encounter when designing and delivering training initiatives for employees [34]. Such challenges often impede the development of a well-skilled workforce that is aligned with organisational objectives and operational requirements. In many organisations, training and development efforts are constrained by inadequate financial resources allocated to employee training [33]. Additional challenges include poor alignment between organisational goals and training initiatives, lack of a comprehensive training needs analysis prior to programme implementation, limited understanding of diverse learning preferences, and resistance to organisational change [18]. Although employers depend heavily on the capabilities, competencies, and knowledge of their human capital to achieve sustained success, persistent skills gaps continue to jeopardise competitiveness and productivity at both operational and strategic levels [15]. Consequently, employers should recognise these complexities and proactively address them when planning and implementing training and development programmes.

2.4 Theoretical framework

The present study was underpinned by Human Capital Theory and Social Learning Theory. Human Capital Theory (HCT) posits that training constitutes strategic investments that enhance long-term earning potential, employee productivity and performance [35]. However, the benefits of such investments are typically realised over an extended period rather than yielding immediate returns [36]. Owing to this delayed payoff, organisations often encounter difficulties in conducting precise evaluations or accurately estimating the return on investment (ROI) associated with training and development programmes [3]. This doubt may contribute to reduced work engagement in training programmes. When employees fail to observe immediate or tangible outcomes, such as direct application of skills or financial rewards, they may perceive limited value in engaging with training initiatives, particularly when perceived outcomes do not align with anticipations [35]. This disconnects between organisational investment and employees perceived returns may, in part, account for the difficulties organisations encounter in fostering sustained engagement in learning and development activities [19].

Deming's [37] exposition of Human Capital Theory frames training and development as strategic investments that entail initial costs but yield long-term benefits, such as enhanced productivity and higher earnings. This view underscores the necessity of designing training and development programmes that are both effective and practice-oriented to ensure the realisation of expected outcomes. A key challenge in this domain is keeping pace with rapid technological advancements, particularly the incorporation of new tools and systems into routine work processes [31]. As a result, learning and development (L&D) professionals must assess employees' existing competence levels, especially in areas related to artificial intelligence (AI) and digitalisation, to identify

requirements for upskilling or reskilling. However, the development of tailored L&D programmes that address specific skills gaps or competency needs is frequently time-consuming and resource-intensive [19].

2.5 Social learning theory

Social Learning Theory, advanced by Albert Bandura in 1977, proposes that learning takes place through observation, imitation, and modelling, and is influenced by factors such as attention, motivation, attitudes, and emotional states [38]. The theory explains human behaviour as the outcome of ongoing interactions between cognitive processes, behavioural patterns, and environmental conditions. Within the wider spectrum of learning theories, social learning is positioned alongside behaviourism, cognitivism, humanism, and constructivism [39]. It is grounded in four core components: differential association, norms and definitions, differential reinforcement, and imitation [40]. In the context of this study, challenges in training and development emerge when employees lack appropriate role models, have limited opportunities for social interaction, receive inadequate positive reinforcement, or are apprehensive about criticism when attempting to adopt new behaviours. Such challenges are often exacerbated by organisational cultures that do not actively promote collaboration, shared learning, or mutual support. Consequently, interactive and engaging training programmes are critical to effective learning outcomes. Addressing these factors can significantly enhance training and development efforts, particularly given that employees differ in their learning styles and that knowledge transfer cannot be uniformly achieved across all individuals.

3 Methodology

3.1 Research philosophy and exploratory research design

This study employed an interpretivist research philosophy alongside an exploratory research design. Interpretivism emphasise comprehension of lived experiences and the subjective meanings that persons attach to a phenomenon [41, 44]. In line with this approach, the study was informed by an interpretivist philosophy with a social constructionist orientation, as it aimed to examine the subjective experiences of both employers and employees in relation to training and development, while recognising how these viewpoints are shaped through interaction within the organisational context. An exploratory research design was adopted to investigate the phenomenon under study, particularly given that the topic has either received limited scholarly attention or has not been sufficiently explained in prior research [42].

3.2 Research approach

The current study employed a qualitative approach underpinned by an inductive approach and situated within a thematic analysis framework, as it sought to explore the personal meanings persons accord to their lived experiences. The approach was particularly suitable for examining participants' subjective perspectives on training and development. Qualitative research generates data in textual form rather than numerical values and focuses on the interpretation of non-quantitative information to gain in-depth insights into individuals' views, perceptions, and expectations [43]. An inductive research approach was adopted to examine the experiences and interpretations of both employers and employees in relation to training. This approach facilitated the generation

of insights and emergent themes derived directly from participants' narratives. Inductive research begins with data collection and analysis and progresses towards the identification of patterns, themes, or theoretical insights grounded in the data [41]. Thematic analysis was selected as the methodological strategy because it aligns with the study's interpretivist philosophy and epistemological assumptions.

3.3 Target population

The target population for this study included individuals who are directly involved in, or affected by, training and development (T&D) activities within organisational environments. This encompassed HR personnel, as well as both existing and newly appointed employees, who were chosen for their capacity to provide informed insights into training and development challenges. However, the exact size of the population could not be determined, as the study encompassed organisations operating across multiple sectors in South Africa. The study adopted snowball and purposive sampling techniques, which are both classified as non-probability sampling methods. Purposive sampling involves the deliberate selection of participants whose characteristics align with the researcher's predefined criteria and the objectives of the study. Snowball sampling, by contrast, entails the recruitment of additional participants through referrals provided by initial respondents, thereby utilising existing social networks to identify individuals who satisfy the study's inclusion criteria [45].

A minimum sample size of 15 participants from the working population was initially targeted, with data collection continuing until saturation was achieved (Table 1).

Table 1 Sample and biographic analysis. Source: Authors Compilation

Participant	Years (organisation)	Highest qualification	Job title	Age	Race	Gender
Participant 1	+ 10	Postgraduate Diploma	Senior HR	35+	Coloured	Female
Participant 2	5	BCom in HR	Senior HR	29	African	Male
Participant 3	9	Master's degree	Managing Director	43	Not disclosed	Female
Participant 4	1, 4 years	BCom Honours	Junior HRM	25	African	Female
Participant 5	12 years	Retail management	Manager	38	African	Male
Participant 6	3 years	Honours degree	Manager	42	African	Female
Participant 7	2 years	Master's	Company Director	60	Indian	Male
Participant 8	5 years	Diploma	Support Officer	56	African	Female
Participant 9	12 years	Bachelor	Social Worker	34	African	Female
Participant 10	4 years	National Senior certificate	Coordinator	22	Coloured	Female
Participant 11	12 years	NQF Level 5	Manager	38	African	Male
Participant 12	4 years	Specialist degree	Administrator	27	African	Female
Participant 13	4 months	Bachelor	Coordinator	23	White	Female
Participant 14	4 months	BCom	Assistant	21	Coloured	Female
Participant 15	1, 5 years	NQF 5	Administrator	26	African	Male
Participant 16	0, 3 years	Bachelor's	Intern	22	African	Female
Participant 17	0, 2 years	Honours	Intern	22	African	Female
Participant 18	0.5 years	National Senior Certificate	Agent	22	Coloured	Female
Participant 19	1, 6 years	Degree	finance clerk	27	Coloured	Male
Participant 20	0,4 years	Information Tech	Developer	26	African	Male
Participant 21	0, 4 years	BCom Degree	Intern	24	African	Female
Participant 22	2,4 years	Bachelor's degree	Intern	24	Coloured	Male

Data saturation was reached at the twenty-second (22th) participant, at which point no new themes were evolving. This section of the study presents the participants' biographical characteristics, including length of service, highest educational qualification, age, race, gender and job title. Table 1 summarises the biographical profile of the study participants.

The investigation indicates that the majority of respondents were female ($n = 14$). This gender distribution suggests representation from a female-led organisational context, as several female participants occupied senior or managerial positions. The sample also reflected a strong representation of Black African employees, who constituted 59% of the participants. This distribution is broadly consistent with South Africa's demographic profile, where Black Africans represent the majority of the population. Further analysis demonstrated that more than 67% of respondents were within the 20–29 age group. An examination of participants' job titles indicated a diverse mix of human resource professionals, senior management, operational staff, and administrative roles. The composition reflects a composed interpretation of HR managers, existing employees and new employees, thereby enabling a comprehensive exploration of training and development experiences across organisational levels.

3.4 Data collection instrument and method

To explore the difficulties in training, semi-structured interviews were utilised to capture participants' subjective experiences. This method was particularly suitable given the study's emphasis on eliciting individual perspectives rather than generating broad generalisations. Semi-structured interviews facilitated focused discussions while affording the researcher sufficient flexibility to explore emerging issues during the interview process, thereby enhancing understanding of the phenomenon under investigation [46]. The study involved interviews with human resource managers and line managers engaged in training and development activities, as well as newly appointed employees with less than two years of tenure and senior employees with more than five years of organisational experience. Each interview lasted approximately 60 min. Interview questions were developed prior to data collection, with additional questions introduced as preliminary insights emerged from the data. Interviews were conducted through both face-to-face interactions and online platforms, including Microsoft Teams, Zoom, and Google Meet. With the informed consent of participants, all interviews were audio-recorded and subsequently transcribed to ensure data accuracy and uphold research rigour. The use of primary data obtained through interviews enabled the study to explore in depth the contextual and environmental factors shaping training practices in the workplace [42].

3.5 Trustworthiness of the data

The trustworthiness of qualitative research is assessed using the criteria of confirmability, dependability, transferability and credibility [46]. Credibility was strengthened through the utilisation of semi-structured interviews, which allowed the researcher to generate rich, in-depth insights into participants' experiences, thereby enhancing the authenticity of the findings. Transferability was supported by offering a clear and detailed account of the research context, including the interview settings (whether conducted virtually or in person), the characteristics of the respondents who experienced training and development challenges, and the procedures used for data collection and

documentation. Dependability refers to the consistency of research findings when the study is replicated in similar contexts. This was addressed by engaging participants from different organisational levels, including human resource managers, newly appointed employees, and experienced employees, thereby capturing perspectives across various stages of organisational involvement. Confirmability refers to the degree to which the study's findings are derived from participants' responses rather than being influenced by researcher bias [47]. To enhance confirmability, the results and research process were subjected to peer review, with four members independently reviewing one another's work to ensure accuracy and objectivity in data collection, analysis, and interpretation.

4 Results

This study utilised thematic analysis to analyse qualitative data obtained from participants. Thematic analysis is a structured and systematic method for identifying, examining, and organising patterns or themes within qualitative data, enabling a rigorous and meaningful interpretation of participants' experiences [48]. The analysis followed the six-phase framework outlined by Braun and Clarke (2006): (1) data familiarisation, (2) initial code generation, (3) theme identification, (4) theme review, (5) theme definition and naming, and (6) report production. All interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed using AI-assisted transcription tools, with subsequent manual verification undertaken to ensure accuracy. A consistent coding and theme development process was applied throughout the analysis, facilitating the identification of recurring patterns during data collection and the iterative refinement of interview questions. To enhance analytical rigour and quality, the 15-point checklist for high-quality thematic analysis proposed by Braun and Clarke [48] was employed. Data were generated through semi-structured interviews with twenty-two participants, and the findings are presented as clearly articulated themes and sub-themes that emerged directly from the data and align with the study's research objectives. Direct participant quotations are included to substantiate and enrich the identified themes.

4.1 To explore the constraints faced by management in the provision of training and development to employees within the organisation

4.1.1 Theme 1: Challenges in identifying training needs

Under this theme, participants highlighted several challenges associated with unclear and overlapping training scopes, which contributed to difficulties in accurately identifying training needs. These challenges gave rise to key sub-themes, including limitations in aligning training design with organisational scope, inadequate employee involvement in the training design process, and ineffective implementation of acquired training outcomes.

Several managers indicated that employees often lacked a clear understanding of the training provided, suggesting gaps in relevance and capability development. In particular, three managers emphasised that the training programmes did not sufficiently address employees' practical needs, thereby limiting their effectiveness. The following participant excerpts illustrate this sub-theme:

"*Upon doing training needs analysis, we noticed that there those e's a vacuum in terms of leadership capabilities, leadership skills and then but upon further interrogation and*

after solving for it. Then there was a decision made that actually no, it's not leadership, they just need more capability in terms of like current technology…" (P6).

"*It's balancing the need of the customer or the person who was requesting the the information with the with the requirements from the service provider"* (P1).

"*It's then people. Not understanding but they said they understand when you facilitating training and was like, no, I didn't understand what was happening there*" (P4).

Participants reached a consensus that misalignment frequently occurs within organisational training and development processes. Although the challenge was initially perceived to stem from deficiencies in leadership capabilities and skills, further evaluation revealed that the underlying issue was predominantly technical in nature. The participant excerpts highlight a clear disconnect in understanding during training sessions, underscoring the importance of effective communication and continuous feedback mechanisms to ensure that training content is adequately understood and applied.

4.1.2 Theme 2: Time allocation for training

The findings associated with this theme emphasise the significance of adequate time allocation for effective training within the workplace. There were a few participants who indicated that they have issues with the time allocation and scheduling of their training. One participant indicated that they were expected to attend training in an external company, but they had to sleep there.

"Sometimes that you have to sleep over, of which I do not like it." (P8).

"*I'd say my biggest challenge was the schedule changed quite a lot, like chopping and changing and stuff like that"* (P13).

These quotes reflect the logistical challenges that participants in training environments experience. They expressed their discomfort with overnight stays and highlighted the unpredictability of scheduling, which can lead to frustration and difficulty in planning.

4.1.2.1 Sub-theme: availability for training Participants highlighted that as managers they face challenges of employees initially scheduled for training but fail to fulfil and avail themselves to attend training.

"It's availability of employees. Yoh sometimes its hard especially for me. A manufacturing perspective like it's hard to get abantu (people) having one people ku training eyone (in one training session) at the same time. So that is one of the things I find challenging." (P4).

"You will have challenges where the training is not maybe going as planned. Sometimes the employee will promise to avail themselves for the training and on the day of the training something comes up. Or a deadline that they need to meet, or a client they need to attend to. Those are practical challenges that I come across at times and other challenges will be from the trainer himself or herself" (P2).

These quotes highlight the lack of availability of employees for training; they highlight how there is difficulty in aligning employees' availability, especially when trying to gather multiple participants at once, and they also highlight how shifting priorities or trainer-related issues often disrupt planned sessions.

4.1.3 Theme 3: Willingness of employee training

Employees' willingness to partake in training programmes is crucial to the success of training initiatives. However, the results indicate that limited employee motivation and

low levels of engagement present a significant challenge, as many employees demonstrate little or no inclination to participate in available training opportunities.

"I've done just too many workshops where I found that. Some people do not even know what you're talking about because they haven't read enough and it's about the work that you're talking about is about what they're supposed to know….When you ask questions, you expect them to answer it because they work with it every day. They do not know it again." (P7).

One manager mentioned the lack of willingness not only affects individual growth in terms of development, but the organisation's growth, as they are stuck with the same practices due to a lack of improvement and skill development.

"It has a very huge impact because remember for us to send employees on training is because there is a business, there is a business need and a business gap that must be filled. All right, so employees, if the attitude of employees is not positive towards training, it means that the outcome of their job, of their work, their performance is going to drop. And if performance is dropping and it's not up to the expected standard. That's where the business struggles to grow in terms of revenues and sometimes even to retain clients because we're a client-based company. So if the clients are not happy with our services because of poor performance from our employees, it means we're going to lose clients, we're going to lose business." (P2).

These quotes indicate that some employees lack foundational knowledge of their own roles, which leads to a disconnect in training. Their quotes also emphasised the importance of training in addressing business needs and performance gaps. They also highlighted the importance of employees' performance in ensuring that clients are satisfied and business sustainability.

4.1.3.1 Sub-theme: Non-voluntary training versus voluntary The participants noted variability in employees' willingness to engage in training initiatives, observing that some employees demonstrated a greater readiness to participate than others, as illustrated below:

"So it's not an issue of someone willing to. it's one of the key issues that we face in that, if people go to training because they're forced to go to training, the participation is impacted." (P6).

"Go for training or not. It's more like it's a compulsory thing because it's in the best interest of the business. So should someone fail to attend trainings, obviously that will, um, that will impact the actual training negatively." (P5).

"…Some people just come to mark the register or to sign the register, in general, a lot of people are not willing enough to go to training and partake in training, and especially if they have to pay themselves. If it's someone paying for them, maybe they'll go if they're forced to go because they're in a workspace that says you have to go for professional development. They will go, but I don't think people do this voluntarily." (P7).

The participant excerpts reveal a persistent workplace constraint characterised by low levels of engagement and voluntary participation in training programmes. Training initiatives are frequently compulsory, which appears to limit meaningful engagement, as employees who are required to attend training often participate reluctantly. The findings further suggest that compulsory training, although designed to meet organisational objectives, may yield suboptimal outcomes when employees lack genuine commitment.

In addition, participants indicated that employees' willingness to engage in training declines when they are required to bear the associated costs, further constraining participation and reducing the overall effectiveness of training and development initiatives.

4.1.4 Theme 4: Trainer competence and knowledge

Managers highlighted the pivotal role of trainer competence and reflected on the complexities involved in developing effective trainers. In particular, they emphasised the criticality of trainers being able to accommodate diverse perspectives and respect the views and opinions of all participants during training sessions, as illustrated below:

"But when we look at facilitating the program, we must accommodate all the views and opinions of the participants" (P7).

4.1.4.1 Sub-theme: importance of trainer knowledge This sub-theme underscores the significance of trainers' professional qualifications and knowledge in ensuring the effective delivery of training programmes:

"And then we also do a lot of training of trainers so that we can implement the training. … So, education is very important, especially in the trainers. and then of course the quality of service they can give and the the higher qualified, more experienced trainers offer better training and therefore better trainees." (P3).

4.1.4.2 Sub-theme: Employee attitude This sub-theme emphasises the significance of employees' attitudes towards training and learning. Participants highlighted the challenge of fostering positive learning orientations among employees, noting that employee receptiveness plays a critical role in the effectiveness of training initiatives. One participant further observed that there is a limited availability of structured learning programmes specifically designed to deliver targeted training solutions:

"People were just focused on doing their job, getting paid. And go home. No interest in development initiatives, so we had to make them see the bigger picture in terms of influencing them to see the necessity for them to partake or to be part of those training initiatives." (P2).

"There aren't many programs that are designed to deliver training and development solutions. You either become you study HR to become a generalist and then you specialize later on By doing SITA or other professional body accreditations" (P6).

4.1.4.3 Sub-theme: Experience of existing and new employees Both newly appointed and existing employees reflected on their experiences with trainers and discussed how trainer effectiveness influenced their learning outcomes, as illustrated below:

"Having a trainer that does not also understand the message that needs to be delivered. … I'll just go back to this whole, you know, two-pot retirement system. So if you're having a trainer that doesn't understand the legislation, if you having a trainer that doesn't really know, you know how this whole two pot system is going to work, so it becomes difficult for you, you know, for an employee at the receiving end to really understand" (P12).

"They didn't really prepare for the induction. 'Cause another thing was when I was getting inducted. And I also joined with some permanent employees as well as some fixed term contract employees. And I think most of the stuff that was happening most of you know the activities, the tasks were mainly for your permanent employees." (P17).

The participant excerpts underscore the importance of inclusive training facilitation that acknowledges and respects the perspectives of all participants. Other accounts emphasise the critical role of well-qualified trainers in delivering high-quality training and producing more competent and confident employees. The findings further reveal recurring challenges, including employee disengagement from development initiatives, structural constraints within training programmes, and the risk of ineffective learning outcomes when trainers lack adequate subject-matter expertise. In addition, some participants reported unsatisfactory induction experiences, particularly highlighting the exclusion of fixed-term employees from formal onboarding and development processes.

4.2 To examine the complexities experienced by both new and existing employees when participating in training and development initiatives within the organisation

4.2.1 Theme 5: Structure and effectiveness of induction training and development in organisations

The findings related to the effectiveness and structure of organisational induction programmes indicate that many participants experienced challenges associated with two key sub-themes: unstructured induction training and mismatched induction content.

4.2.1.1 Sub-theme: Unstructured induction training This sub-theme addresses the largely informal nature of induction training provided to newly appointed employees. The following excerpts from new employees illustrate experiences that align with this sub-theme:

"Honestly, it was very informal. I'm not sure if it was because I'm joining HR so as one of their own. You don't get the same experience that the rest of the candidates get" (P14).

Three participants indicated that the induction process was excessively lengthy and could have been made more effective through better preparation and a stronger emphasis on practical, job-relevant components.

"The induction was four weeks long, so it was very long, like I spent three days in some of the departments and halfway through the first day, they'd already showed me everything they wanted to show me." (P13).

"The effectiveness I think they could be more effective in them being more practical right off the bat and I suppose when it comes to the process of them integrating you into the business, I think they can really like nudge it a bit more" (P15).

"I'm also thinking maybe they were not prepared, they didn't really prepare for the induction." (P17).

4.2.1.2 Sub-theme: Mismatch induction training Participants reported challenges associated with training delivered by external service providers, noting that such training was often confusing and poorly aligned with organisational needs, resulting in a mismatch between training content and practical job requirements. The following participant excerpts illustrate this sub-theme:

"And I don't believe it's too effective. From a training perspective, because I think more of our roles are based on learning on the job", "So the training and induction process or the effectiveness of it, I'd say it's relatively low." (P19).

"The individuals at this external company or this external company, a lot of or each one had very different thing they were telling us how it was a bit confusing at the beginning." (P22).

Overall, the participant excerpts suggest that human resource employees experience onboarding differently from other employee groups. Participants highlighted inefficiencies in the duration of induction programmes, alongside a lack of practical integration into organisational operations. Several accounts pointed to insufficient preparation and limited effectiveness of induction processes, with much of the learning occurring informally through on-the-job experiences. In addition, inconsistent messaging from external facilitators was reported to have contributed to confusion during the early stages of employment. Collectively, these findings underscore the need for more structured, well-prepared, and practice-oriented induction programmes to enhance the effectiveness of training and onboarding initiatives.

4.2.2 Theme 6: Management communication channels

The findings of this study indicate that employees often feel intimidated when seeking assistance from management. Participants expressed uncertainty about whether it is appropriate to request support beyond the scope of the training provided, alongside concerns about being perceived as incompetent. These perceptions appear to inhibit help-seeking behaviour, thereby limiting opportunities for learning and skill development.

"I don't know if you have much of a leeway in terms of, you know, seeking guidance from them outside of what they can tell you." (P15).

"I don't know if it's just my personality, but like I would never have said anything like you've just walked into a new company. It is quite intimidating." (P13).

"No, I don't think so, you don't want to seem as if you're incompetent, or you don't know what you are doing" (P17).

4.2.2.1 Sub-theme: New to corporate language Two participants reported difficulties in understanding organisational jargon, which contributed to confusion during their work and training experiences. The following participant excerpts illustrate this sub-theme:

"Industry, language and when he tells me mean I understand it according to my own understanding." (P20).

"Terminology. So, the language is quite like the language within the team. Very different because, obviously a lot of new set of products, new set of just general ideas that one isn't exposed to." (P15).

The participant excerpts indicate that employees experienced constraints in seeking guidance from management, alongside difficulties in understanding organisational jargon. Participants further expressed concerns about being perceived as incompetent, which contributed to hesitation in requesting assistance, particularly within environments perceived as intimidating. In addition, structural communication barriers associated with hierarchical chains of command, as well as the use of unfamiliar language and concepts, were identified as factors that hinder effective onboarding and impede smooth integration into the organisation.

4.2.3 Theme 7: Implementation of training

This theme examines the differing experiences of existing and newly appointed employees with regard to the implementation of training and development programmes. The following sub-themes emerged from the analysis:

4.2.3.1 Sub-theme: Poor employee engagement in training design Participants reported that managers often do not engage sufficiently with employees to understand their training needs or involve them in the development of training initiatives. As a result, employees experienced difficulties in comprehending the training content, which they perceived as poorly aligned with their practical requirements.

"Managers don't really engage with the employees and really understand the employees and let them be part of the training development programs that they develop for employees." (P12).

4.2.3.2 Sub-theme: Poor implementation of training acquired Some newly appointed employees perceived the training as insufficiently comprehensive, noting that organisational policies were not clearly explained. Participants also reported difficulties in applying the training in practice, particularly with regard to understanding and aligning with the organisation's strategic objectives.

"Have difficulty grasping the severity of certain sanctions. So as an employee, I feel like it would also be difficult for me to grasp all of the sanctions" (P10).

"…They just did not explain very clearly like some of their policies or one thing they would do is not go in depth. So they didn't go in depth. … They just handed us over to our managers and yeah, and that that was it." (P17).

"The challenge I faced was understanding the strategies of the organisation 'cause. There are a lot so trying to like see where I fit in this position they gave me with the strategy they are trying to achieve. But that's it's." (P16).

In addition, existing employees identified the following challenges related to training and development:

"…But we've had the challenge of transports you know mostly we are working with the community we we can't be in the office every day we have to go out." (P9).

"… Undergoing the implementation of certain procedures like incapacity procedures and quantum procedures, those are rather difficult for me. It depends on the facilitator" (P10).

Overall, the participant excerpts indicate a lack of managerial engagement in understanding employees' needs and meaningfully involving them in training initiatives. Participants further highlighted challenges in comprehending organisational policies and sanction procedures, largely due to insufficient clarity and explanation during training. The findings also reveal confusion regarding organisational strategies and employees' ability to align their roles and responsibilities with these strategic objectives. In addition, participants identified contextual constraints, including transport-related challenges in community-based work, as well as procedural difficulties, such as those associated with incapacity and quantum processes, which were perceived to be heavily dependent on the effectiveness and competence of training facilitators.

4.2.4 Theme 8: Training programs not aligned to employees' personal goals

Training and development programmes are intended to address employees' developmental needs and support their career progression. Organisational training initiatives should therefore be sufficiently flexible and inclusive to accommodate the diverse needs of all employees. However, one participant reported not having received any training from the organisation, highlighting gaps in the accessibility and equitable provision of training and development opportunities.

"*Well, no. Well, no, no. Yeah. No because there was no training programme.*" (P 17).

"I wouldn't say it's in line with your personal goals, so my personal goal is to end up in design because I've got a degree in clothing, retail management and stuff. So, what I'm doing currently is just a lot of admin where so there's not much like, there's no creativity…" (P 13).

"Um, to a certain extent, yes, and to a certain extent no. Um. Because the the delivery in which it's done does not align to how I to how I effectively learn." (P 22).

The participant excerpts reflect a clear misalignment between training experiences and individuals' needs, career goals, and preferred learning styles. Participants highlighted instances of a complete absence of formal training programmes, as well as a disconnect between their current job roles and personal aspirations, noting that their positions lacked relevance to their qualifications. In addition, concerns were raised regarding training delivery methods that failed to accommodate diverse learning preferences, further limiting the effectiveness of training and development initiatives.

4.3 To investigate the environmental factors that compromise the effectiveness of training and development within the organisation

4.3.1 Theme 9: Technological integration for training and development

This theme explores how employees and employers are increasingly embracing the integration of technology into training initiatives. While technology utilisation has enhanced the efficiency and effectiveness of training initiatives, it has also introduced new constraints for both managers and employees. Four interviewees reported that, although the incorporation of technology in the organisation was perceived as beneficial, it was also experienced as challenging due to limited technological understanding and digital competence.

"Right now, technology is hard for people who are about to go on pension. It's hard for them to grasp a lot of things" (P4).

"Yeah, it's a bit of a challenge really, because we are old school sometimes, we are not used to this technology technologies. Yeah, I remember. It's one stage I was not used with visual and stuff like that. Then I had that that someone was presented here making noise that then we chatting on the side so I didn't even know where to switch off the mike." (P8).

"…Are not updated in terms of technology updates, technology improvements. They're not going to be able to utilise the current technology systems… For an example during COVID I came to a realisation that most of my managers, internal managers, they didn't have the capacity to work fully online" (P2).

The participant excerpts illustrate that older employees and managers encountered notable challenges in adapting to rapidly evolving technological systems. These challenges were particularly evident in difficulties understanding and using new digital tools. Participants described themselves as "old school," highlighting unfamiliarity with virtual

Table 2 Summary of findings. Source: Authors' compilation

Research objectives	Themes
1. To explore the constraints faced by management in the provision of training and development to employees at the workplace.	1 Identification of training needs obstacles 2 Limited allocation of time for training 3 Unwillingness of staff to engage in training 4 Poor trainer knowledge and competence
2. To examine the complexities experienced by both existing and new employees when participating in training and development initiatives at the workplace.	5 Unorganised structures and ineffectiveness of induction training at the workplace 6 Poor communication channels 7 Ineffective implementations of training 8 Poor alignment between employees' personal goals and training programmes.
3. To investigate the environmental factors that hinder the effectiveness of training and development at the workplace.	9 Weak technological integration for training. 10 Poor financial support and limited physical resources.

platforms and basic digital functions, such as managing microphone settings during online interactions. The findings also point to a broader issue of limited digital competence among some managers, a challenge that became especially pronounced during the transition to remote and online work prompted by the crisis.

4.3.2 Theme 10: Resources and financial support

For training and development initiatives to be effective, it is essential that organisations invest adequately in their human capital. However, managers reported insufficient resources and limited financial support to implement the desired training and development programmes, noting that proposals were often rejected by the finance department.

"We have challenges with procurement in, in terms of funding. You know sometimes they don't approve it because it's too costly and stuff." (P16).

"I think with ours they not enough. Because we tried everything, but because of the different age gaps that we have, it's kinda not accommodating to everyone. Others are not for Gen Z, these others are not for millennials, so it's kinda difficult, yeah." (P4).

Overall, the participant excerpts highlight significant procurement and funding constraints, with cost considerations frequently resulting in the rejection of essential training resources. The findings further indicate that existing training efforts are inadequate, as generational differences among employees contribute to misaligned training provision. In particular, the inability to accommodate the distinct learning needs and preferences of both Generation Z and millennial employees was identified as a key challenge, thereby limiting the success of training initiatives.

5 Discussion

The Table 2 shows the summarised challenges faced by HR managers, veteran and new employees.

- To explore the constraints faced by management in the provision of training and development to employees at the workplace.
- To examine the complexities experienced by both existing and new employees when participating in training and development initiatives at the workplace.
- To investigate the environmental factors that hinder the effectiveness of training and development at the workplace.

5.1 To explore the constraints faced by management in the provision of training and development to employees within the organisation

The results indicate that the identification of training needs constitutes a major constraint for organisations. This challenge is further compounded by the need to balance multiple responsibilities while meeting the diverse expectations of various stakeholders. This finding aligns with prior study by Bitrian et al. [19], who emphasised that analysis of training needs is a critical component of the training process, as it facilitates the identification of gaps in staff's knowledge and skills. However, Suravi [3] found that poor training content quality, unclear training objectives, and difficulties in ensuring the practical application of acquired knowledge and skills are the key challenges in training and development. Accordingly, conducting a comprehensive needs analysis is essential to ensure that training initiatives are both effective and relevant. Collectively, these challenges underscore the importance of carefully designing and implementing training programmes that are clear, relevant to employees' needs, and aligned with organisational objectives. One effective approach to addressing these challenges is the systematic conduct of training needs analysis.

In addition, the results revealed that faced with inadequate time allocation for training in the organisation. Consistent with prior research, time constraints were identified as a key barrier to the development of employees [49]. Similarly, Othayman et al. [33] underscored the importance of organisations prioritising training and development through the allocation of adequate time and resources to facilitate effective employee learning. Furthermore, the present study demonstrates that limited time availability remains a major constraint in the implementation of training initiatives, as employees often encounter scheduling conflicts that hinder their participation. Suravi [3] indicated that inadequate time for reinforcement and practice contributes to employees forgetting training content and failing to apply newly acquired skills in practice. These findings collectively suggest that organisations must strategically prioritise training and development and ensure the allocation of adequate time and resources to enhance learning retention and practical application.

This study also identified lack of proper trainer competence and subject-matter knowledge as the barrier to effective delivery of training programmes. This finding aligns with Rowland et al. [4], who observed lack subject expert and competence negatively impacts the training effectiveness. However, Assen [50] found that that potential trainee needs to be sufficiently equipped with relevant prior competencies, skills and knowledge to engage in continuous improvement initiatives. Pinho et al. [39] observed the central role of trainers in facilitating development, noting that their expertise and instructional capability are important for accomplishing training objectives. Effective trainers are required to accommodate diverse employee perspectives during training sessions and to possess the appropriate qualifications and expertise to deliver training efficiently. Accordingly, poor trainer expertise emerges as as constraint to the effective implementation of training programmes.

5.2 To examine the challenges experienced by both existing and new employees when participating in training and development initiatives within the organisation

This objective presents insights into the challenges experienced by both existing and new employees in relation to training. The findings illustrate how these employee

groups perceive and experience training initiatives within their organisations. Key challenges identified include deficiencies in the structure and effectiveness of induction programmes, communication barriers, difficulties in implementing training outcomes, limited willingness to engage in training, and misalignment between training programmes and individual career goals. The study reveals that newly appointed employees perceived induction programmes as falling short of their expectations and insufficiently aligned with their specific job roles. The current study established that the induction process as confusing and, in some cases, excessively lengthy. The results further indicated that induction managers appear inadequately prepared, contributing to mismatches between training content and job requirements. Overall, the induction process was perceived as informal and ineffective, with employees indicating that organisations often expected them to acquire role-specific knowledge informally through on-the-job learning rather than during structured induction. These findings are consistent with Chuang [5], who identified key induction-related challenges, including limited role clarity, insufficient experience among induction facilitators, and the absence of customised induction content tailored to diverse roles and employee needs.

The study established that employees often feel intimidated when communicating their training needs or concerns to management. The trainees expressed apprehension that requesting assistance might lead management to question their competence or negatively evaluate their performance. As a result, employees were reluctant to raise challenges or seek clarification. These results align with prior research by Clarke [14], which identified persistent communication barriers between managers and employees in organisational settings. In addition, newly appointed employees reported difficulties in understanding the corporate language used within their organisations. Limited familiarity with organisational terminology hindered their ability to comprehend role expectations and contributed to confusion during the early stages of employment. The current study further indicated that misunderstandings arising from unfamiliar language discouraged them from speaking up, as they feared social exclusion and marginalisation within the organisational culture. These findings are consistent with Bahrain et al. [51], who observed that the use of unfamiliar terminology can impede effective communication and foster feelings of exclusion among employees. Similarly, McCarthy and Milner [15] found that reliance on a single standardised organisational language may create communication barriers rather than facilitate understanding for all employees.

The findings of this study revealed ineffective execution of training programmes as a substantial challenge. This finding aligns with existing literature that highlights ineffective training implementation compromise training initiatives [5,18]. In addition, the study indicated that limited managerial engagement hindered managers' understanding of employees' developmental needs and reduced employee involvement in the design of training initiatives, resulting in difficulties in comprehending and applying training content. These results are further supported by Assen [51], who highlighted the criticality of training in facilitating the acquisition of technical skills related to process improvement and in fostering social interaction within organisations. However, the present study also reveals that employees may exhibit resistance to change and limited commitment to training outcomes when they lack clarity on how to implement quality management concepts and process improvement techniques in their roles. In addition, Ramachandran et al. [52] observed that the training programmes' effectiveness is influenced by

multiple factors, including training quality, content relevance, and the level of organisational support, all of which were identified as critical in the current study.

The findings indicate that both employees and senior executives demonstrate limited willingness to participate in or financially support training initiatives. The distinction between voluntary and compulsory training emerged as a key sub-theme, underscoring the need for management to foster a culture of continuous learning that actively encourages voluntary participation in training and development programmes. The importance of organisational support in fostering employee development has been emphasised in prior research by Firmansyah and Saepulo [38], who identified organisational support as a key factor of employee engagement and motivation in training programmes. The results are also consistent with the view of Pradhan and Shrestha [53], who demonstrated that effective top-level leadership practices enhance employees' affective commitment by positively shaping perceptions of their work and its contribution to performance improvement. Similarly, Chanani and Wibowo [54] highlighted the significance of continuous learning and development, conceptualising it as an ongoing organisational process that requires sustained motivation, opportunities, and facilitation from the organisation. The findings support Social Learning Theory (SLT), which suggests that learning takes place through observation and imitation and is influenced by factors such as attention, motivation, and attitudes [38]. In this context, employees' attitudes towards training are critical, and cultivating positive learning orientations is essential for effective training outcomes. Both new and existing employees shared experiences that highlighted the influence of trainer competence on their learning processes. Consistent with SLT, the findings suggest that training challenges arise in environments characterised by the absence of clear role models, limited opportunities for social interaction, insufficient positive reinforcement, and fear of criticism when employees attempt to adopt new behaviours.

The findings further indicate that employees who perceive training as misaligned with their personal career goals tend to regard such initiatives as ineffective. Some participants reported receiving no training opportunities, while others indicated that the training provided failed to consider their individual career development needs. In support of these findings, Saul et al. [55] emphasised the importance of aligning employees' personal development plans with organisational training and development strategies in order to prevent negative performance outcomes. Training initiatives are therefore intended to support employees' career development and improve their understanding of job roles. However, as employees increasingly seek to personalise their career paths in line with individual aspirations, organisations must take these goals into account to enhance employee retention.

5.3 To investigate the environmental factors that hinder the effectiveness of training and development at the workplace

The findings of this study indicated that the integration of technology has emerged as a key challenge for both employees and managers in the context of training and development. A major concern identified was the limited understanding and inadequate training in the use of digital technologies, which hinder organisations' ability to effectively incorporate technology into training initiatives. The study indicated that insufficient technological knowledge constrained their capacity to fully integrate digital tools into

both their work practices and training activities. Age was also identified as a contributing factor. Older employees expressed concerns about their ability to keep pace with technological change, with some perceiving themselves as too old to adapt to new digital systems. Conversely, managers perceived older employees as less willing to embrace technological advancements. In addition, the introduction of technology into training and development programmes was often met with resistance from employees. While organisations increasingly rely on technology-based training solutions, they frequently overlook the need to first equip employees with foundational digital skills.

This finding is supported by Leuhery [56], who observed that a key limitation organisations encounter when bringing technology into training is the failure to provide initial training on how to use technological tools effectively. Similarly, Ramachandran et al. [53] demonstrated that while technology-enhanced training can improve growth, save time, support skill acquisition, and boost employee confidence, its effectiveness depends on continuous and appropriate training, given the rapid pace of technological change. Furthermore, Cau-Bareille et al. [57] emphasised that skills diversity is often overlooked in training design and cautioned that the introduction of technology should not disregard or devalue the existing skills and experience that employees bring to the workplace.

The study revealed that employees often experience limited financial support for training and development, with proposed initiatives frequently rejected due to budgetary constraints. Even when funds are allocated to human resource departments, they are often insufficient to support the comprehensive implementation of desired training and development programmes. As a result, training initiatives tend to be overly generic and fail to accommodate the diverse learning needs of employees, thereby constraining effective learning outcomes. The study further indicates that organisations often accord limited strategic importance to training and development, perceiving it as an expense rather than a long-term investment. This perspective is consistent with Pradhan and Shrestha [53], who indicated that difficulties in measuring the return on investment (ROI) of training and development initiatives discourage organisations from committing substantial resources to such programmes. For training and development initiatives to be effective, organisations must demonstrate a willingness to invest adequate financial resources in their human resource functions. This requires a strategic shift in perspective, whereby employees are viewed as valuable human capital rather than organisational costs.

5.4 Practical implications of the study

The results of this study indicate that the identification of training needs remains a significant organisational challenge. Consequently, human resource managers should conduct comprehensive training needs analyses to accurately identify areas requiring employee development. The study further revealed that newly appointed employees perceived existing induction programmes as misaligned with their roles and insufficient in meeting their expectations. To address this gap, managers are encouraged to design structured onboarding programmes that integrate both theoretical instruction and practical application, thereby aligning training initiatives with employees' roles and organisational objectives. In addition, the study found that employees often feel intimidated when communicating their training needs or concerns to organisations. Organisations should therefore foster a psychologically safe environment that encourages employees to seek support without fear of victimisation. Clear explanations of organisational

terminology and processes are also essential to support employee understanding and integration. Establishing open communication channels can facilitate continuous feedback and enhance the effectiveness of training delivery. Furthermore, the findings indicate limited willingness among both employees and senior executives to participate in or financially support training initiatives. In response, human resource managers should implement flexible training schedules and design programmes that explicitly link training participation to career progression opportunities. Such approaches are likely to enhance employee motivation, increase engagement in training activities, and strengthen organisational commitment to continuous learning.

The study indicated that employees often demonstrate limited willingness to participate in training initiatives. Employees are therefore encouraged to adopt a more proactive approach by actively engaging in training programmes, seeking clarification when necessary, and viewing training as an opportunity for professional growth rather than a compliance requirement. The findings further revealed that newly appointed employees perceived induction programmes as misaligned with their roles and insufficient in meeting their expectations. To address this, employees should seek regular feedback to ensure the effective application of acquired knowledge and skills, while also providing constructive feedback to human resource managers regarding training content and delivery to inform improvements in future training initiatives. In addition, the study identifies technology as a persistent challenge for both employees and managers in training and development contexts. Employees should therefore communicate technological difficulties promptly and demonstrate openness to using digital platforms integrated into training programmes. Such engagement can contribute to smoother training experiences and enhance the overall effectiveness of technology-enabled learning initiatives.

5.5 Theoretical implications of the study

This study advances the Human Resource Development literature by systematically identifying the distinct training and development challenges faced by newly appointed employees, existing employees, and employers. By explicitly differentiating among these groups, the study reveals the specific constraints experienced at various organisational levels and underscores the necessity of tailoring training and development (T&D) initiatives to the particular needs of each employee category. Such a differentiated perspective enables training departments to formulate more focused and effective change management and development strategies. In addition, the study draws attention to the evolving modalities of training delivery in the context of rapid technological advancement. It demonstrates that the increasing demand for T&D is driven by continuous and often unpredictable technological change, which requires ongoing upskilling and reskilling to reduce the risk of skills obsolescence. This insight highlights the significance of adaptive learning frameworks and strategic workforce development in maintaining organisational competitiveness. Collectively, the study addresses a notable gap in the literature by offering empirical evidence on the complex challenges associated with the design and implementation of training and development initiatives in contemporary organisational settings.

6 Conclusion

The study found that training and development are influenced by a wide range of interrelated factors, including ineffective induction processes, communication barriers, difficulties in identifying training needs, limited organisational resources, poor trainer competence, and resistance to technological change. External pressures, such as rapid technological advancement, the rise of hybrid work models, and financial constraints, further complicate the effective design and implementation of training programmes. The findings also revealed that organisations across diverse industries experience similar challenges in the development and execution of training initiatives at multiple organisational levels. Importantly, the study demonstrates the need for managers to develop tailored training programmes for newly appointed and existing employees, taking into account their distinct challenges, career aspirations, and developmental requirements. The adoption of differentiated change management approaches is therefore essential to effectively support these employee groups. A key limitation of the study is the relatively limited theoretical grounding available on workplace training and development challenges, which constrained the extent to which the findings could be linked to existing theoretical frameworks. Future research should consider adopting a longitudinal research design to capture employees' training and development experiences over an extended period, thereby providing deeper insights into the evolving nature and long-term impact of training initiatives.

Author contributions

NKK, NHK, EK and NRM: Methodology, Writing – original draft, Validation, Software, Formal analysis. RU: Visualization, Funding acquisition, Writing-review & editing, Supervision, Resources, Investigation. NKK, NHK, EK and NRM: Validation, Writing – review & editing, Project administration, Conceptualization.

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Data availability

The raw data supporting the conclusions of this article will be made available by the authors, without undue reservation.

Declarations

Ethics approval and consent to participate

This study obtained ethical clearance from by IPPM Research Ethics Committee of the University of Johannesburg (Reference number: IPPM-2025-976(H)). Accordingly, this study was conducted in accordance with the local legislation and institutional requirements. The participants provided their written informed consent to participate in this study before collection of data.

Consent for publication

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